



△ ARCHED CROSSING

The three-arched Ponte Vecchio connects the center of Florence with the district of Oltrano to its south; Oltrano means “across the Arno.”

Ponte Vecchio

A medieval survivor spanning the Arno River as a monument to commerce



S. Europe

When the Ponte Vecchio—the shop-lined bridge that crosses the Arno River at its narrowest point in Florence, Italy—was built in 1345, it would not have been that special. At that time, most urban bridges were covered with shops and stalls, as well as spaces for tables where merchants could show their wares. What makes the Ponte Vecchio special is that the shops have survived to the present day. Initially, butchers plied their trade on the bridge; today, it is jewelers, art dealers, and tourist souvenir sellers. Interestingly, the concept of bankruptcy started on the bridge, as a money-changer’s table (*banco*) would be broken (*rotto*) by soldiers if he could not pay his debts.

Third time lucky

The Ponte Vecchio is the third bridge to have stood on this site. The first was built by the Romans, with stone piers and a wooden superstructure. After that bridge was destroyed in a flood in 1117, it was rebuilt, but again swept away in 1333. The current bridge has a main arch span of 98 ft (30 m), with two side arches each 89 ft (27 m) in width. The arches rise 11½ ft–14½ ft (3.5–4.4 m) above the river. Running along the top of the bridge is Vasari’s Corridor, an enclosed, private corridor built by Giorgio Vasari, court architect to the Medici ruling family, in 1565. The corridor connects the Palazzo Vecchio, Florence’s town hall, with the Palazzo Pitti, the Medici family palace, on the south bank.